Sidorov was given two days to turn over the command of his old regiment to another officer and assume command of the regiment assigned to Cuba. His first task was to move his new regiment to Sevastopol in the Crimea. They began loading their rockets and equipment—some eleven thousand tons of weaponry and supplies—on train platforms on the night of Sidorov's first day in command. Nineteen trains would be required to move the cargo to Sevastopol and six ships, including the *Omsk*, to take it to Cuba. The loading of the *Omsk*, like the other ships headed for Cuba, took place in utmost secrecy. The port was guarded by special troops, and the officers and soldiers on the loading dock were forbidden to leave the area or have any contact with the outside world.

The R-12 rockets were loaded onto carts that were then secured in the cargo holds. It was a risky undertaking, but they had to conceal the missiles from the eyes of American pilots, whom they knew they would encounter in the Atlantic. Another major risk came with placing trucks in the cargo holds loaded with cisterns of hydrogen peroxide used to power the pumps of the missile combustion chambers. They put the trucks in wooden boxes and fixed them on special platforms to avoid accidental collision with the cisterns. Finally, they put their engineering equipment and civilian trucks needed for the construction of missile platforms on deck in full view of anyone who cared to look at it: after all, the *Omsk* was allegedly bringing civilian cargo to Cuba.[7]

To help maintain secrecy, before leaving Lithuania for Sevastopol they loaded the train with a supply of winter clothes—allegedly the troops were heading north. But once the train reached the port of Sevastopol, the officers and men were given summer clothes to wear. To everyone's surprise, these were civilian outfits. According to a participant in the operation, "enlisted men and sergeants" were dressed "in suits, check shirts of various colors and cloth caps, while officers wore suits, white or light-colored shirts, and hats. There were suits even for the enlisted men, also of various colors, and fairly fashionable for the time: single-breasted jackets of middle length in a variety of styles. We looked at one another in bemused surprise, not recognizing ourselves in 'civvies.' "[8]

Colonel Sidorov and some of his men left Sevastopol on August 4 with a load of six R-12 missiles. The ship was designed to carry no more than